

SendGrid Account Setup — Manzil

Case-processing & transactional email | Prepared 22 August 2026

SendGrid discontinued its permanent free tier on 27 May 2025. What's offered on signup now is a 60-day trial only (100 emails/day, 100 contacts) — sending stops automatically at day 60 unless the account is upgraded to a paid plan before then. There is no ongoing free option for production use.

Setup Steps

1. Sign up for a SendGrid account

Create the account at signup.sendgrid.com. This starts the 60-day trial (100 emails/day, 100 contacts) — usable for dev/testing only, not production, since sending is cut off at day 60.

2. Upgrade to the Essentials plan (\$19.95/mo, 50,000 emails/month)

Do this before the trial expires. At Manzil's current volume (~500 clients/month × 2 emails/case ~ 1,000 emails/month, plus a few hundred more for Phase 1 Auth password-reset/notification emails), this is only ~2% of the Essentials cap — about 25x headroom before the next tier (100,000 emails/month at \$29.95/mo) is needed.

3. Verify sender identity (domain authentication)

Settings -> Sender Authentication -> Authenticate Your Domain, for the sending domain (e.g. manzilconsultancy.com). This is required before production sending and gives better deliverability than single-sender verification, plus support for multiple from-addresses (e.g. [noreply@](mailto:noreply@manzilconsultancy.com), [admin@](mailto:admin@manzilconsultancy.com)).

4. Add the DNS records SendGrid provides

Add the CNAME records shown in the dashboard to the domain's DNS provider (these configure SPF/DKIM), then click Verify in SendGrid once they've propagated.

5. Create a restricted API key

Settings -> API Keys -> Create API Key -> Restricted Access, granting only the Mail Send permission (not Full Access). This limits the blast radius if the key is ever leaked.

6. Store the API key securely

Add it as a backend environment variable (e.g. `SENDGRID_API_KEY` in `.env`), never committed to git — same pattern as the other secrets in `backend/.env.example`.

7. Set up the event webhook (optional, recommended)

Settings -> Mail Settings -> Event Webhook, to receive delivery/bounce/spam-report events back into the app if send-status visibility is wanted later.

8. Test at low volume before rolling out

Send a handful of real case-processing emails and check Activity -> Email Activity in the SendGrid dashboard for delivery status before enabling it broadly.

Note: the app itself has no SendGrid/email integration wired up yet (no SMTP/mail code in the backend) — the steps above cover account setup only. Building the sending logic (SendGrid Node SDK, email templates, wiring the API key into config) is a separate follow-up task.

Email Cost by Growth Scenario

Clients/month	Emails/month (×2)	Plan needed	Monthly cost
500 (current)	1,000	Essentials	\$19.95
10,000	20,000	Essentials (still under 50k cap)	\$19.95
12,500	25,000	Essentials -> next tier (100k)	\$29.95
50,000	100,000	Pro	\$89.95

Bottom line: at the current volume, email cost is a flat \$19.95/month (Essentials) —

there's no free production tier anymore. That single plan covers roughly 25x the current client volume before a bigger tier is needed.

Sources

- Twilio SendGrid Email API pricing — [twilio.com/products/email-api/pricing](https://www.twilio.com/products/email-api/pricing)
- SendGrid Trial Account Plan (official support article) — confirms the free plan is now a 60-day trial only, not permanent